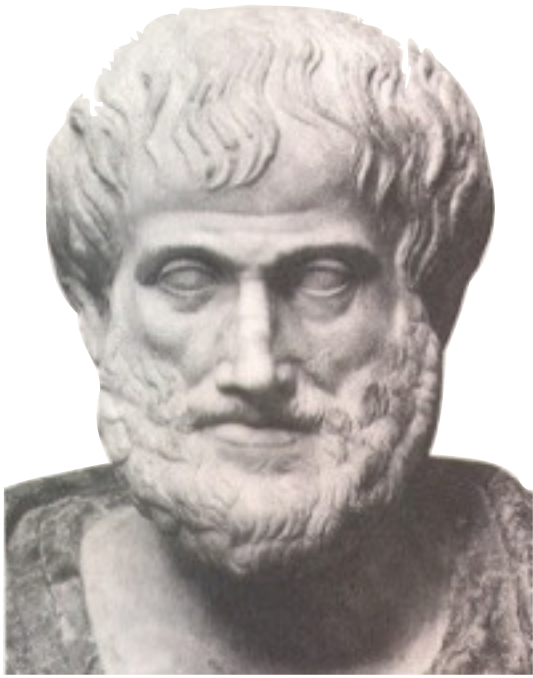


An argument for the reality of fate was given by the
ancient Greek philosopher Aristotle.

So let's ask the question: is there such a thing as fate?



Aristotle's argument begins with a statement of the following logical principle:

We might imagine that all of the facts about your life — past, present, and future — are written down in a dusty book in a library somewhere. So, for example, near the end of the book in the first quarter of the book, one might find the sentence ‘[insert your name here] entered South Dining Hall at 5:46 on 3/24/2019, and filled [his/her] plate with beef stroganoff.’

Of course, there is no such book. But, if fate is real, then there could be. The truths are all there, whether or not they have been written down.

Suppose that you came across a book of this kind, which listed all of the actions you have undertaken, and and suppose you had proof that the book was written well before your birth. Would this cause you to doubt that your actions were free? (This is kind of like the story about Osmo in the reading from Taylor for today.)

If so, then it seems that the very existence of fate should cause you to doubt your free will. After all, the book would not have made you do anything. So whether or not the book was really written seems irrelevant.

The law of the excluded middle

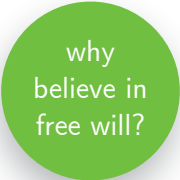
For any proposition P , either P is
true or $\text{Not-}P$ is true.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

Why might one think this is true? Propositions say that the world is a certain way. It seems that there are just two possibilities: either the world is that way, or it is not. In the first case, the proposition is true. In the second case, its negation is true. So, either way, either P is true, or $\text{Not-}P$ is true.

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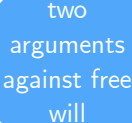
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responding to Edwards' argument. But

first let's think about how Edwards'

We'll shortly consider some ways of

argument might be related to an argument

for fatalsn.

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

Suppose that someone did not believe in

similar to Edwards' argument?

there were truths about all our future

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

actions. Could they give an argument

God only shows up in premises (2) and

our future actions.

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

with reference to the being of truth about



God knows that in the future I will

5* We have noticed that the fact

0 We have achieved what we

1. We have no direct facts.

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

2* In the past, there were truths about

then we have the choice about q.

some action, then I will prefer that

all of our activities.

that if it is true that I will perform

(3, 4, 5)

acaioid.

3 We have not at the fact that

will perform various actions.



perform a certain action (1,2)

The fatalist argument

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

things as fate, then there is no free will.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

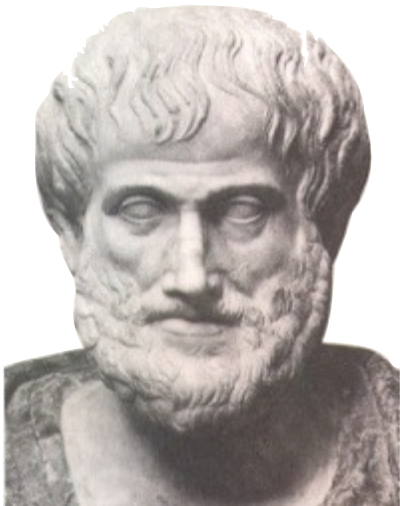
freedom that comes from fate.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to



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